

THE SHORT GUIDE

START HERE

*A calm guide to the federal process, for the people inside it
and the families beside them*

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a physician who went through it

This short guide is free. Share it with anyone who needs it.

The full book and audio are at newphysician.org.

MOVEMENT ONE — THE SHOCK AND THE SHAPE

CHAPTER ONE

The Map You Never Got

If you are reading this, something has happened that cracked your world open. You didn't get a warning. You didn't get a manual. You didn't get a map.

The worst part is not the event itself. It is the not knowing. The mind fills the dark with monsters.

So let me give you the first truth. You are not weak. You are not doomed. You are not alone. You are simply standing at the beginning of a road no one ever prepared you for.

This book is the map. Not a promise. Not a prediction. A map. A road with stages. A road with edges. A road with an end.

You cannot fight a fog. But you can walk a road. And I will walk it with you.

CHAPTER TWO

The First Week

The first week is the most dangerous week. Not because of what the government will do, but because of what fear will make you do. So here are the rules that keep you safe.

Say less. Fear makes people talk too much, and talking makes trouble.

Write nothing you would not read aloud in court. Assume everything is recorded, because it might be.

Contact no one connected to the case. Not to explain, not to apologise, not to fix. Good intentions can become new charges.

Destroy nothing. Deleting looks worse than anything you deleted.

Tell only who must know. Every extra person is a leak.

Get a lawyer before you get advice. Everyone has opinions. Only one person has a licence.

This week feels like the end. It is the beginning.

CHAPTER THREE

What Your Lawyer Does

Your lawyer handles the criminal case. That is the job. Charges, plea, sentencing, that lane.

But the federal process is not one body. It is many. The court. The licensing board. The certification body. The exclusion system. The databases. The reentry system.

Your lawyer handles the first body. You must prepare for the rest. This book teaches you the rest.

CHAPTER FOUR

How to Talk to Your Lawyer

Fear erases memory. Paper does not. So arrive with written questions. Ask for the range, best, worst, most likely. Ask what to do now. Ask what they are not handling. Write the answers down before fear wipes them.

Busy is normal. Blunt is normal. Guarantees are not.

You are allowed to understand your own case. Ask until you do.

MOVEMENT TWO — THE MACHINERY

CHAPTER FIVE

The PSR

The presentence report is the document that follows you everywhere. It shapes where you go, what level you are assigned, what programmes you can reach, how early you might come home.

The interview matters. Your story matters. Errors matter. Read it line by line. Correct everything. Add the truth of who you are.

This document outruns the sentence.

CHAPTER SIX

Sentencing

Sentencing feels like fate. It is not. It is a structure. The grid is the starting point. The human factors are where mercy lives. The record you build is your influence.

You cannot change the past. You can change what the judge sees.

Build the case for mercy. Do not beg for it.

MOVEMENT THREE — THE STACK

CHAPTER SEVEN

What the Court Did Not Take

Read your judgment. Slowly. The court tells you exactly what it is taking. But the silences matter too.

Often the court does not take your profession. It could have. It did not.

Every body that comes after will pretend the court ended your career. The court did not. That gap is your defence.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Stack

The court speaks once. The system keeps speaking. One body after another. Board. Certification. Exclusion. Databases.

None of them coordinate. None of them see the whole. Punishment accumulates.

Naming the stack removes half its power. You cannot be blindsided by what you can see.

CHAPTER NINE

The Licensing Board

The board reacts to the conviction, not your competence. Two documents matter: the notice of intent, and the final order.

A notice is not the end. It is the beginning of a process. You almost always have a right to respond. Silence is surrender.

Do not surrender.

CHAPTER TEN

The Exclusion

Exclusion lasts longer than prison. It bars you from federal programmes. The number of years is built from factors, some unfair.

Then come the databases. They record everything. They follow you for decades.

Know what they block. Know what they do not. Know your deadlines. A list is not your worth.

MOVEMENT FOUR — STANDING THROUGH IT

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Telling Family

Tell the people you love before they hear it elsewhere. With children, match the truth to the age. Lead with safety. Say: you are safe, I love you, this is not your fault.

Do not over-explain. Do not rush their feelings. Keep the door open.

Love survives this.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Marriage

This weight strains marriages. It does not mean either of you failed. Some marriages survive. Some do not.

If yours does not, grieve it. But do not lose yourself.

Do not make irreversible decisions in the worst week.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Waiting

Waiting is its own hard. You cannot control the outcome. You can control the day.

Structure is a railing in the dark. Move your body. Guard ordinary moments. Shrink the horizon to today.

Steady does not mean unafraid. Steady means doing the next right thing anyway.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

The First 90 Days

Coming home is not easy. It is its own challenge. Learn the rules exactly. Technical violations send people back faster than anything.

Build a rhythm fast. Stack small wins. Keep every appointment.
Be straight with your officer.

Reentry is a skill. Not a switch.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Life After

This is a chapter. Not the whole book. You may lose a
credential. Grieve it.

But you were never only that credential. What made you good
is still yours. Reinvention is architecture, not consolation.

You lost almost everything. And you are still standing. That is
where the next thing begins.



This was the short version

What you just read is the whole road in brief, the map in skeleton. I wrote it so that anyone, on the worst day, could read the entire thing in one sitting and feel the fog lift a little.

There is a fuller version, where each step is walked slowly, with the things nobody tells you and the parts I lived myself. It is available as an audiobook and in print at newphysician.org.

But this short guide is yours, free, to keep and to share. If someone you know is standing where you were when you opened it, send it to them.

The author has pleaded guilty to a federal offense and does not seek to relitigate his conviction or minimize his responsibility. This is general information from lived experience. It is not legal advice for any individual case.
